

Episode 29: Special Episode – Theatrical *CLANNAD* Release Commemoration – Stories with Director Dezaki Part 2

For certain reasons, I've been intensively watching *The File of Young Kindaichi* (金田一少年の事件簿) DVDs lately. The anime version (laughs). A work I previously did colour design and colour direction for. I helped with the recently released DVD-BOX packaging work, and through that connection I forcibly got the DVD-BOX! (Sorry)

The File of Young Kindaichi initially started as cel-film work but switched to digital colouring mid-series, which involved considerable trial and error.

Oh yes, recently cable channels have been rerunning it too, and for a while before summer I got quite hooked watching it. It was quite fresh to carefully rewatch a work I'd designed so long after on TV. Man, *Kindaichi* was pretty well made (laughs).

Well, I plan to write about *The File of Young Kindaichi* here eventually, so please look forward to it (laughs).

Lately there have been increasing murder and assault cases that surpass anime and manga. Due to such influence, broadcasts of *School Days* final episode and *Higurashi no Naku Koro ni Kai* (ひぐらしのなく頃に解) have been suspended in some regions. Well, these incidents probably aren't because anime had similar depictions. But it must be tough for broadcasters in various ways.

This reminded me - ah, when we were doing *Kindaichi*, several shocking real-world incidents occurred too. We never had broadcast suspensions, but some episodes were abandoned at script stage.

I mean, stories like "rolling severed heads" or "dismembering mummies for tricks" - impossible for terrestrial TV at 7 PM (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Continuing the *CLANNAD* theatrical release commemoration special episode.

About every 10 days to 2 weeks, overall storyboard meetings. Usually 15-20 minutes late, the director would arrive casually. When the tall director appeared casually at the meeting room doorway, everyone instantly switched to sharp meeting mode. The director's walking and speaking style were relatively "casual" and soft, but the eyes behind sunglasses, though gentle, gleamed sharply, making us tense up too (laughs).

Each meeting progressed checking settings for each department. Character designs, costume designs, art designs, art boards, etc. For character colour checking, I'd have the director sit next to me, receiving instructions and giving opinions while making various adjustments. "That's it. Like this, light comes in whoosh, and shadow on this side properly..." said Director Dezaki.

However, since character visuals were decided to remain true to the original, I couldn't make shadow colour contrast overly strong in basic design. The key became how to treat those characters within main story scenes.

The original visuals were "soft and soft, clean but fluffy," so I really wanted to make outline (main line) colours lighter and brighter, but actually trying it - while decent in still images, in moving pictures they either dissolved too much into backgrounds or floated too much. So I kept it to just slightly softer. Naturally, according to spatial brightness, character colours, main lines, colour tones, and density were all adjusted accordingly.

As the director's storyboards progressed and overall meetings accumulated, storyboards gradually diverged from the scenario. "Somehow, that's what happened," said the director. Oh no, naturally he explained the reasons to us (laughs).

That change held major meaning within theatrical *CLANNAD*. And "Ah, this is Director Dezaki." Well, Producer K-san seemed nervous though (bitter laugh).

Then storyboards were complete. Overall meetings finished too.

"Ah, meetings are over..." I felt somewhat disappointed, wanting to have many more meetings, but naturally that wasn't possible (bitter laugh). After this, based on director meetings, we below the director would GO! with main story work. Well, as usual our time was limited (bitter laugh).

For theatrical *CLANNAD* I basically handled colour design, colour direction input, and final finishing delivery checks alone, but I'm not very fast and it was 1,400 cuts. We urgently got a young female colour director named Akimoto-san (秋元) as assistant to handle various impossible demands for miscellaneous items.

Still, pushing the original schedule back as much as possible, editing and dubbing. After filling in images to take shape, all main staff including the director participated in full-length checking and retake assignments.

Overall director notes were given, then detailed processing checks for each cut. Numerous revision instructions. Honestly, quite a few cuts needed rework. Adding more photography processing, the screen gradually thickened.

We processed all retake cuts and delivered the tentative complete package. Our work went that far. Then the director added his "one more spoonful." Once all images were OK, video editing would be redone and the director would comprehensively add further processing.

Then the zero screening.

For movies, negatives are made and positive film printed for theatres screening. "Zero screening" means screening the first print of the completed full movie to do final checks before mass print production. Here you can ask lab staff to adjust print exposure, colour readjustment, and printing corrections as needed.

The producer, directors, and script supervisor who attended video editing knew the "complete version" where the director added his "one spoonful," but we were watching the "complete version" for the first time at this zero screening. The screening room darkened and screening began. Hmm, indescribable tension...

And 90 minutes. Screening ended. Great relief. "Hmm, I see!" I thought. The director's added "one spoonful" had greatly increased theatrical *CLANNAD*'s sharpness and three-dimensionality as a movie.

In the waiting room after screening, I told the director who was smoking: "You added quite a bit, didn't you? (laughs)" "Well, something like that," the director grinned. Thus theatrical *CLANNAD* was completed.

Later, at the wrap party after the first screening at Toei Studios screening room. At the end of the excited after-party, I had a firm, gentle but strong handshake with Director Dezaki. "Man, thank you. You really helped a lot," said Director Dezaki. Man, I was moved. So happy! I don't know if I'll get to work with the director again, but I'll work hard dreaming of collaborating again someday!

(07.09.25)